

Gulf Coast Charters Network — Go Live Checklist

Professional launch path · Alabama Gulf Coast · Print and check off in order

A. Decide what “live” means

- **Preview (now):** GitHub Pages for design / sales demos — mightyorganix-dev.github.io/gulf-coast-charters-network/
- **Professional (money + real guests):** Custom domain + Vercel (site + Stripe deposit API) + real operators, legal, and auth

B. Brand & domain

- Pick final domain (example: gulfcoastchartersnetwork.com) and buy it
- Set business email: book@... · captains@... · hello@...
- Lock brand / LLC (or operating entity) with counsel or filing service
- Keep sister brand link: Gulf Coast Spearfishing in nav/footer

C. Hosting for real payments (Vercel)

- GitHub Pages is fine for brochure; **deposits need Vercel** for `/api/create-checkout-session`
- Vercel → Import [mightyorganix-dev/gulf-coast-charters-network](https://github.com/mightyorganix-dev/gulf-coast-charters-network)
- Build: `npm run build` · Output: `dist` · Connect custom domain · HTTPS green
- Keep GitHub as source of truth; Vercel redeploys on push

D. Stripe deposits (money path)

- Create Stripe account (business details, bank, tax ID) — start in **Test** mode
- Vercel → Settings → Environment Variables (never in GitHub, never in chat): `STRIPE_SECRET_KEY`
- In `src/js/stripe-config.js`: set `publishableKey`; `checkoutEndpoint` stays `/api/create-checkout-session`; set `enabled`: `true` only after secret is in Vercel
- Test checkout with Stripe test card → then switch to live keys and retest a small refundable deposit

E. Replace demo data with real inventory

- Replace seed captains, boats, trips with real operators
- Verify USCG credentials (as required), insurance COI, ADCNR / federal compliance literacy
- Signed operator / IC agreements on file; real marina GPS and boarding instructions
- Real pricing, duration, capacity, deposit %; live availability calendar; professional photos

F. Guest experience (must work before ads)

- Booking end-to-end on phone + desktop; deposit + confirmation email
- Guest itinerary / boarding pass with real confirmation codes
- Weather policy in plain language (Green / Yellow / Red + deposit credit)
- What to bring, safety, FAQ, contact — accurate for Gulf Shores · Orange Beach · Fort Morgan · Perdido

G. Captain + admin (before real PII)

- Add real login/auth on captain-portal and admin — do not leave open with guest data
- Captains see only their manifests; admin manages Items / Resources / Channels / bookings

H. Comms & ops

- Business phone (or Twilio/OpenPhone); SMS/email templates for weather alerts
- Cancellation / weather / tip policy in writing; safety escalation list
- Daily ops: who answers, who marks weather, who reconciles Stripe

I. Legal & insurance (professional floor)

- Entity + EIN; business + marine/charter insurance per vessel
- Website terms, privacy policy, booking agreement (deposits, no-shows, weather)
- Accurate advertising (no guaranteed catch); counsel review before paid public bookings

J. Soft launch → public launch

- Soft launch: 3–5 trusted guests book real deposits; fix friction
- Then Google Business Profile / local SEO; ads and marina partnerships only after soft launch works
- Monitor Stripe + inbox daily for the first two weeks

K. Day-of publish (short)

- DNS → Vercel · HTTPS OK · Stripe live keys in Vercel only · `enabled`: `true`
- One successful live deposit + refund · real trips/captains · demo seed gone

- Auth on captain + admin · phone/email answered · weather/cancel linked from book flow
- Sister Spearfishing link works · mobile hard-refresh looks correct

Already built

- Premier hub (Zeke-style guest IA + FareHarbor-style Items / Resources / Channels)
- Activity-matched trip images · cinematic watersports hero
- Stripe API stub + deposit % · captain portal · itinerary · admin
- GitHub source of truth

Still blocks professional money

- Custom domain on Vercel
- Stripe secrets + enabled: true
- Real operators / legal / insurance
- Auth before real guest PII
- Live availability + SMS/email ops

Gulf Coast Charters Network · Confidential operating checklist · Revoke GitHub PATs after every push · Stripe secrets only in Vercel env